Week 9: Leadership, Discussion, Meetings and Ethics

NPTEL Soft Skills · Prof. Binod Mishra · Lectures 41–45

Contents

1. Lecture 41: Leadership Skills
2. Lecture 42: Group Discussion: Part I
3. Lecture 43: Group Discussion: Part II
4. Lecture 44: Meeting Management
5. Lecture 45: Adaptability and Work Ethics

Lecture 41: Leadership Skills

Week 9 · Course book PDF pages 669–683 (printed pages 668–682)

Learning objectives

- Identify traits and characteristics of a leader.
- Describe leadership styles: autocratic, democratic, laissez-faire, transactional, transformational.
- Explain initiating structure and consideration, and Fiedler's contingency model.
- Describe charismatic and visionary leadership.
- List cultural differences in leadership and the elements of trust.

Important definitions

LEADER

A person from among the group who initiates action, guides members and helps the group reach its goal; not necessarily a manager.

AUTOCRATIC LEADER

Takes decisions on his own ideas, with little interest in members' problems.

DEMOCRATIC LEADER

Considers members' interests, takes suggestions and arrives at a solution acceptable to all.

LAISSEZ-FAIRE LEADER

Gives members full autonomy and does not intervene.

TRANSACTIONAL LEADER

Guides followers towards established goals by clarifying roles and task requirements.

TRANSFORMATIONAL LEADER

Inspires followers to transcend self-interest and brings profound change.

INITIATING STRUCTURE

Leader behaviour that defines tasks, work relationships, goals, standards and deadlines.

CONSIDERATION

Leader behaviour that builds mutual trust, respects ideas and feelings, and cares for members' welfare.

LPC (LEAST PREFERRED CO-WORKER)

Scale in Fiedler's model measuring whether a leader is task-oriented or relationship-oriented.

CHARISMATIC LEADER

Leader with heroic, extraordinary qualities, vision and commitment, an agent of radical change.

VISIONARY LEADERSHIP

Leadership offering a clear, compelling image of an innovative future that taps people's energy and emotions.

Core concepts

Who is a leader

- A leader is 'among us', not from heaven; example of a passenger who organised a solution after a flight was diverted to Bhopal instead of Jabalpur.
- Distinguish a manager from a leader.
- Traits: intelligence, charisma, decisiveness, enthusiasm, strength, bravery, integrity, self-confidence.
- Characteristics shown: **initiative**, desire to lead, honesty, integrity, **subject knowledge**, concern for others.

Styles of leadership

- **Autocratic** – not considered good; ignores problems of members.
- **Democratic** – involves everyone, weighs pros and cons, acceptable solution.
- **Laissez-faire** – autonomy; no interference.
- **Transactional** – assigns tasks and roles.
- **Transformational** – goes beyond role, sees a new tomorrow.

Dimensions of leader behaviour

- **Initiating structure:** assigns tasks, expects standards and deadlines.
- **Consideration:** trust, respect, concern, well-being.
- Leaders **high on both** bring better products and solutions; too much consideration may cause absenteeism.

Fiedler's model

- Fred Fiedler (spelt Fielder in the transcript): effectiveness depends on the match between the leader's style (measured by LPC) and the degree of control and influence the situation gives.
- Leadership style is **fixed**: either task-oriented or relationship-oriented.
- A relationship-oriented leader may neglect the task and cost the organisation.

Charismatic leadership

- Followers attribute heroic qualities; leaders show commitment, vision, confidence; agents of radical change (politics, religion, business).
- Rise above petty self-interest; articulate the vision; participative; pioneers of change; aware of environmental concerns.

Visionary leadership

- Clear and compelling imagery of an innovative future; draws on traditions and connects to actions people can take.
- Taps energy and emotions, creating enthusiasm like for sports.
- Visionary leader **explains the vision**, has no hidden agenda, expresses it through behaviour and action, extends it to different contexts.

Transactional versus transformational

- Transactional: roles and task requirements.
- Transformational: inspires followers to transcend self-interest, instils courage, profound effect.

Cultural differences in leadership

- **Koreans:** paternalistic, mentors.
- **Arabs:** strict; kindness seen as weakness.
- **Japanese:** humble, speak little.
- **Scandinavians and Dutch:** do not praise individuals in public.
- **Americans:** talk of responsibility, rationality, value orientation and hedonism.

Trust: the hallmark of an effective leader

- **Integrity** (honesty, words match action)
- **Competence** (subject knowledge)
- **Consistency**
- **Loyalty** (to organisation and coworkers; represents their case assertively)
- **Openness / candidness**

The leader is the sailor guiding the ship; members are passengers.

Closing quotation

Warren E. Bennis: "Leadership is the capacity to translate vision into reality." Are leaders born or made? Both – they emerge from among us and are made by their qualities (to be seen in group discussion).

Types, classifications and characteristics

Leadership styles

Style	Feature
Autocratic	Own decisions, rigid
Democratic	Participative
Laissez-faire	Hands-off autonomy
Transactional	Roles, tasks, rewards
Transformational	Inspires beyond self-interest
Charismatic	Heroic, vision, radical change

Elements of trust

Element	Meaning
Integrity	Honesty; word = action
Competence	Knowledge of the subject
Consistency	Same action for same problem
Loyalty	Sacrifice and defending co-workers
Openness	Candid, clear explanation

Theories, principles, models and contributors

CONTINGENCY MODEL — FRED FIEDLER (AS 'FIELDER')

Effectiveness depends on matching the leader's style (task or relationship oriented, measured by LPC) with situational control.

LEADERSHIP DEFINITION — WARREN E. BENNIS

Leadership is the capacity to translate vision into reality.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Passenger organising alternative transport after the Bhopal landing.

EXAMPLE

Korean paternalistic leaders; Arab strictness; Japanese humility.

EXAMPLE

Scandinavian leaders avoid public praise.

Comparison tables

Transactional versus transformational

Point	Transactional	Transformational
Focus	Roles and tasks	Vision and change
Followers	Guided to established goals	Inspired to go beyond self-interest
Effect	Maintains	Profound change

Initiating structure versus consideration

Point	Initiating structure	Consideration
Focus	Task, deadlines	People, trust
Risk if excessive	Neglects members	Absenteeism

Autocratic, democratic and laissez-faire

Style	Decision making	Member involvement
Autocratic	Leader alone	Low
Democratic	Shared	High
Laissez-faire	Members decide	Full autonomy

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- A leader emerges from the group.
- Five styles: autocratic, democratic, laissez-faire, transactional, transformational.
- Initiating structure and consideration are two dimensions.
- Fiedler: leadership style fixed; task or relationship oriented.
- Charismatic leaders have vision and conviction.
- Transformational leader inspires beyond self-interest.
- Trust elements: integrity, competence, consistency, loyalty, openness.
- Bennis: capacity to translate vision into reality.
- Koreans paternalistic; Arabs strict; Japanese humble.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W0 Q5	p.1	Leadership and motivation	True/False
W9 Q1	p.31	Leadership styles	MCQ
W9 Q2	p.31	Visionary leadership	MCQ
W9 Q3	p.31	Charismatic leadership	MCQ
W9 Q8	p.32	Meaning of leadership	MCQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

A leader emerges from the group and shows initiative, integrity, knowledge and concern. Styles are autocratic, democratic, laissez-faire, transactional and transformational. Leader behaviour has two dimensions, initiating structure and consideration, and Fiedler's model links effectiveness to the fit between a fixed task or relationship style and the situation. Charismatic and visionary leaders inspire change; leadership differs across cultures. Trust, built on integrity, competence, consistency, loyalty and openness, is the hallmark. Bennis: leadership is the capacity to translate vision into reality.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) Which style gives members complete autonomy?

A. Autocratic
B. Democratic
C. Laissez-faire
D. Transactional

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** Leader does not intervene.

Q2 (MCQ) 'Leadership is the capacity to translate vision into reality' is by:

A. Drucker
B. Bennis
C. Tuckman
D. Orwell

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Warren E. Bennis.

Q3 (MSQ) Elements of trust include:

A. Integrity

B. Competence

C. Consistency

D. Secrecy

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** Openness, not secrecy.

Q4 (T/F) According to Fiedler, a leader's style is fixed.

> **Answer:** True
> **Why:** Task or relationship oriented.

Q5 (Fill) Scandinavian and Dutch leaders avoid _____ praise of individuals.

> **Answer:** public
> **Why:** It is considered impolite.

Q6 (Short) Differentiate transactional and transformational leaders.

> **Answer:** A transactional leader guides followers to established goals by defining roles and tasks; a transformational leader inspires them to rise above self-interest and brings profound change.
> **Why:** Transformational is one step ahead.

Revision checklist

☐ I can list leader traits.

☐ I know five styles.

☐ I know Fiedler's model.

☐ I can describe charismatic and visionary leaders.

☐ I can list elements of trust.

Lecture 42: Group Discussion: Part I

Week 9 · Course book PDF pages 684–702 (printed pages 683–701)

Learning objectives

- Define group discussion (GD) and explain its importance in selection.
- Differentiate debate and GD.
- Describe GD set-up: seating, size, time, topic announcement.
- Differentiate topic GD and case GD.
- List language, qualities evaluated, individual and group responsibilities, and leadership types in a GD.

Important definitions

DISCUSSION

An exchange of knowledge and experience among people.

GROUP DISCUSSION (GD)

A formal, face-to-face, unstructured, cooperative discussion among participants who exchange views on a topic; a dialogic learning process.

DEBATE

A formal, structured contest with participants speaking for or against a motion.

MOTION

The topic of a debate, supported by the ‘for’ speakers and opposed by the ‘against’ speakers.

TOPIC GD

A GD on an announced topic, often unstructured and announced on the spot.

CASE GD

A GD based on a printed real-life or imaginary case where the group is expected to reach a solution.

DIALOGIC

In the form of a dialogue among many people.

BULLDOZER

A dominating, selfish participant who tries to overpower the group.

INERT PARTICIPANT

A member who does not participate and needs encouragement.

Core concepts

Why GD matters

- Organisations use GD as a criterion to **shortlist/eliminate** candidates when applicants are many and vacancies few, often followed by another test.
- It also helps in crises as a means to find remedies; it has an inbuilt mechanism of correction.
- Evaluates traits: awareness, reasoning, behaviour, initiative, motivation, assertiveness, listening, leadership, teamwork.

Debate versus GD

- Both are formal and face-to-face.
- Debate: **structured**, fixed sides (for/against), topic given in advance (a week or ten days), competitive, emotional, flowery language.
- GD: **unstructured**, flexible (a participant may change stance), topic often announced on the spot, cooperative atmosphere, facts and simple language.

Set-up of a GD

- Seating **circular or semi-circular** so all see each other.
- Usually **7–10** participants.
- Time: 15, 20 or 25 minutes (decided by organisers).
- Topic announced; a few minutes to think; keywords ignite thoughts.
- No rule on who speaks first or in what order; no designated leader.

Topic GD versus case GD

- **Topic GD:** clear topic announced.
- **Case GD:** detailed printed case (real or imaginary); tests analytical, decisive and reasoning skills; aim is a solution; suggestions of ways may be offered.
- Flexibility is the hallmark of both.

Language and phrases

- Simple, concise, appropriate, persuasive and polite; avoid flowery, pompous, obsolete or sesquipedalian words.
- Starting: “Today we have gathered to discuss…”.
- Strong view: “I strongly feel…”, “I am convinced…”, “I am pretty sure…”.
- Neutral: “According to me…”.
- Making a point: “May I make a point about…?”, “I think it is important to consider…”.
- Agreeing: “I fully agree with what Mohan says.”
- Disagreeing politely: “That may be your personal view; my view is…”.
- Returning to the topic: “Could we stick to the topic?”, “I fear we are deviating…”.

Qualities evaluated

- **Awareness**, **reasoning** with facts, **behaviour** (group dynamics matter more than content), **initiative**, **motivation** (encourage the quiet), **assertiveness** (not aggression), **listening**, leadership and team skills.

Responsibilities

- **Individual:** speak, behave well, listen, show interest.
- **Group:** commit to group goals, keep a conducive and amicable atmosphere, resolve conflicts, ensure full participation, keep cohesion; differences should be ideological, not personal.

Leadership in GD

- No designated leader; anyone can lead at any time; tested in conflict or chaos.
- **Driver** – initiates.
- **Amiable** – speaks little, neutral; not acceptable.
- **Democrat** – best; restores order and shares time.
- **Bulldozer** – dominating, selfish; can be cut to size by exposing weak logic.

Body language

Must never be negative; accept opposition graciously through eyes, face and posture; show commitment. “A group swims and sinks together.”

Types, classifications and characteristics

Types of GD

Type	Features
Topic GD	Topic announced; unstructured
Case GD	Printed case; aim at solution

Leadership types in GD

Type	Behaviour	Acceptable?
Driver	Starts discussion	Yes
Amiable	Silent, neutral	No
Democrat	Orderly, shares time	Best
Bulldozer	Dominates	No

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Job fair using GD to shortlist.

EXAMPLE

College debates for and against a motion.

EXAMPLE

Phrases like ‘Could we stick to the topic?’.

Comparison tables

Debate versus group discussion

Point	Debate	Group discussion
Structure	Structured, ordered	Unstructured
Sides	For or against fixed	Flexible stance
Topic	Given in advance	Announced on the spot
Tone	Competitive, emotional	Cooperative
Language	Flowery, ornamented	Simple, factual
Purpose	Win the argument	Exchange and reach conclusion

Topic GD versus case GD

Point	Topic GD	Case GD
Input	Announced topic	Printed case
Aim	Discuss views	Reach a solution
Skills tested	Awareness, expression	Analysis, decision making

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- GD is formal, face-to-face, unstructured and cooperative.
- Debate is structured with motion for/against.
- GD seating: circular or semi-circular.
- 7–10 participants; 15–25 minutes.
- Two types: topic GD and case GD.
- No designated leader in GD.
- Leader types: driver, amiable, democrat, bulldozer.
- Group dynamics matter more than content.
- Body language must be positive.
- Participants have individual and group responsibilities.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W8 Q1	p.28	Group discussion etiquette	True/False
W9 Q4	p.31	Definition of group discussion	Fill-in-the-blank
W9 Q5	p.31	Benefits of group discussion	MCQ
W9 Q6	p.32	Group responsibilities	MCQ
W9 Q7	p.32	Role of the leader in discussion	MCQ
W9 Q10	p.32	Evaluation criteria in group discussion	MCQ
W9 Q12	p.33	Purpose of group discussion	True/False

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Group discussion is a formal, unstructured, cooperative, dialogic exchange used to shortlist candidates. Unlike a structured, competitive debate with fixed sides, GD allows flexible stances and uses simple, factual, polite language. Held in a circle or semi-circle with 7–10 participants for 15–25 minutes, it may be a topic GD or case GD. Evaluators look for awareness, reasoning, behaviour, initiative, motivation, assertiveness, listening and leadership; participants have individual and group responsibilities. Leaders may be drivers, amiable, democrats or bulldozers.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) GD is best described as:

A. Structured and competitive
B. Unstructured and cooperative
C. One-sided
D. Informal chat

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Cooperative and flexible.

Q2 (MCQ) Which type of leader is best in a GD?

A. Bulldozer
B. Amiable
C. Democrat
D. Dictator

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** A democrat keeps order.

Q3 (MSQ) Differences between debate and GD include:

A. Debate is structured

B. GD allows change of stance

C. Debate topic is given in advance

D. GD uses flowery language

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** GD uses simple language.

Q4 (T/F) A GD has a designated leader chosen beforehand.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** Anyone can lead.

Q5 (Fill) A GD is typically seated in a circular or _____ arrangement.

> **Answer:** semi-circular
> **Why:** Everyone must see each other.

Q6 (Short) What is a case GD?

> **Answer:** A GD in which a printed real or imaginary case is given and the group is expected to analyse it and reach a solution.
> **Why:** Tests analytical and decisive skills.

Revision checklist

☐ I can define GD.

☐ I can differentiate debate and GD.

☐ I know topic vs case GD.

☐ I know the qualities evaluated.

☐ I know leader types.

Lecture 43: Group Discussion: Part II

Week 9 · Course book PDF pages 703–718 (printed pages 702–717)

Learning objectives

- Explain the role of an emergent leader and the LEADER acronym used in the lecture.
- Describe what panelists observe in a GD.
- List the dos for preparing and participating in a GD.
- List the don’ts in a GD.
- Recognise types of GD topics and the need for decorum.

Important definitions

EMERGENT LEADER

A leader who is not designated but emerges from the group by taking initiative to bring the discussion back to the main issue.

PANELIST

The evaluator who observes participants’ speech, behaviour and non-verbal conduct, usually noting points.

INERT (SILENT) PARTICIPANT

A member who does not participate; he becomes a liability to the group.

HIGH / LOW PARTICIPATOR

Members who speak often or rarely; panelists note changes in participation.

CHAIRMAN ROLE

Giving judgment; participants must not assume it.

BULLDOZER

A dominating member who creates chaos; can be countered by exposing flaws in his logic.

DECORUM

Proper behaviour in a discussion, free from gender, cultural or ego bias.

Core concepts

Role of leader in GD

- Saves the group from being sidetracked (like a boat in the middle of a river).
- Resolves conflicts, summarises, encourages silent members, keeps participation going.
- Leader types: specific, implied, **emergent**, designated – in GD the leader is **emergent**.
- Influence by constructive participation and rational thoughts; build support among supporters and logically weaken opponents' view.

LEADER acronym (lecture's analysis)

- **L**iberal – not rigid; ensures everyone participates.
- **E**ager and enthusiastic.
- **A**ssertive – without arrogance; influence by constructive ideas.
- **D**emocrat – everyone gets a chance; nobody's sentiment is hurt.
- **E**rudite – subject knowledge.
- **R**ational – no discrimination.

Also: good communication ability. (The lecture lists these traits in running speech; the letter mapping follows the speaker's explanation.)

What panelists observe

- Who started, who speaks more or less, who became silent, who keeps the ball rolling.
- Reactions to others: gesture, posture, pitch and loudness of voice.
- Whether anyone is hurt (religion, ethics) in controversial topics.
- Shifts in participation: support, opposition or attempts to subdue.
- Consistent involvement – not one speech followed by 'golden silence'.

How to prepare / dos

1. Seat yourself **comfortably** (non-verbal behaviour).
2. **Listen to the topic** carefully; keywords ignite thoughts.
3. **Organise thoughts** before speaking; speak complete, grammatical sentences with follow-up points.
4. Speak at the **earliest opportunity** without snatching; be patient.
5. Politely intervene if someone speaks too long: "May I share my piece of mind...".
6. Identify supporters and opponents; augment or counter.
7. Keep track of time; share time fairly.
8. Maintain **eye contact** while speaking and listening.
9. Persuade silent members politely.
10. Use a proper pitch, intonation and articulation; speak at a pace others follow.
11. Define the problem when sidetracked; look at both sides of the coin.

Don'ts in a GD

- Do not be in a hurry to start; never remain silent.
- Do not dominate; **influence** through constructive, rational, factual views.
- Never take the role of a **chairman** or an extreme, judgmental stance.

- Do not argue with opponents or whisper with supporters; no value judgments.
- Do not look at the panelist to impress; do not use slang to shout at silent members.
- Do not move excessively forward or show physical weight.
- Do not put all ideas in one go or speak too fast.
- Do not digress; avoid gender, cultural or ego issues.

GD topics

- **Factual** (e.g. brain drain should be stopped; human cloning should be banned), **abstract**, **fictional**, **controversial** (e.g. no reservation in jobs; transfer of religious places; 'money makes happy, but too much money makes us unhappy').
- Take a solid stand based on logic; discuss, do not quarrel; consensus is desirable but not always possible.

Types, classifications and characteristics

GD topics

Type	Example
Factual	Brain drain should be stopped
Factual/policy	Human cloning should be banned
Abstract / fictional	Imaginative or conceptual topic
Controversial	No reservation in jobs; religious places

Dos and don'ts summary

Do	Don't
Listen to the topic	Dominate
Organise thoughts	Act as chairman
Maintain eye contact	Whisper or argue
Share time	Speak too fast or all at once
Encourage silent members	Look at the panelist

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Boat in the middle of a river without a leader.

EXAMPLE

Crowded bus: creating your own space.

EXAMPLE

Polite phrase: ‘Mr Suraj may be right in a particular situation, but every situation has its own requirements.’

Comparison tables

Influence versus dominate

Point	Influence	Dominate
Method	Constructive, rational, factual ideas	Loudness, weight, interruption
Result	Emerges as leader	Seen as a bulldozer

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- The GD leader is emergent.
- Silent members are a liability to the group.
- Panelists observe both verbal and non-verbal behaviour.
- Listen to the topic carefully; keywords matter.
- Organise thoughts; use complete sentences.
- Never take the role of a chairman.
- Don’t whisper or argue; maintain eye contact.
- Influence, don’t dominate.
- Topics: factual, abstract, fictional, controversial.
- Consensus not always necessary; exchange of views is.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W8 Q1	p.28	Group discussion etiquette	True/False
W9 Q9	p.32	Group discussion do's and don'ts	MCQ
W9 Q10	p.32	Evaluation criteria in group discussion	MCQ
W9 Q14	p.33	Group discussion conclusion	True/False

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

In a GD the leader emerges from the group; he is communicative, liberal, eager, democratic, assertive, erudite and rational, saves the group from conflict, summarises and encourages silent members. Panelists observe participation, tone, gestures and fairness. Prepare by sitting comfortably, listening to

the topic, organising thoughts, speaking early but politely, sharing time, maintaining eye contact and encouraging others. Avoid dominating, acting as chairman, extreme stands, arguments, whispering, looking at the panelist, over-speed and digressions. Topics may be factual, abstract, fictional or controversial; a solid, logical stand and decorum are essential.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) The kind of leader in a GD is:

A. Designated

B. Hereditary

C. Emergent

D. Elected

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** A leader emerges on his own initiative.

Q2 (MCQ) Which role should a participant NOT take?

A. Encourager

B. Chairman

C. Supporter

D. Listener

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Participants discuss; they do not judge.

Q3 (MSQ) Which are don’ts in a GD?

A. Whispering with supporters

B. Looking at the panelist

C. Maintaining eye contact

D. Speaking too fast

> **Answer:** A, B, D
> **Why:** Eye contact is recommended.

Q4 (T/F) Staying silent in a GD is safe because it avoids mistakes.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** Silence makes you a liability.

Q5 (Fill) Instead of dominating, a participant should _____ the group.

> **Answer:** influence
> **Why:** Through constructive ideas.

Q6 Short How should a silent member be handled?

> **Answer:** Politely encourage and persuade him to speak, without shouting or using slang.
> **Why:** The group is judged collectively.

Revision checklist

- ☐ I know the emergent leader’s traits.
- ☐ I know what panelists observe.
- ☐ I can list GD dos.
- ☐ I can list GD don’ts.
- ☐ I know GD topic types.

Lecture 44: Meeting Management

Week 9 · Course book PDF pages 719–731 (printed pages 718–730)

Learning objectives

- Define a meeting and list its functions.
- Identify reasons why meetings fail.
- Plan a meeting by answering why, who, when, where and what.
- Conduct a meeting: start on time, follow the agenda, allow participation, record minutes.
- State participant etiquette and the leader's closing duties.

Important definitions

MEETING

An organised gathering of people for a specific purpose, called to share information, train, solve problems, plan, receive/demonstrate products and make decisions.

AGENDA

A list of items to be discussed, circulated in advance to give members first-hand information.

MINUTES

The official record of what was discussed and decided; unpleasant incidents are not recorded.

VENUE

The place where the meeting is held.

FIASCO

A meaningless or failed meeting with no outcome.

FOLLOW-UP ACTION

Assigning responsibilities and deadlines after the meeting.

Core concepts

Functions of a meeting

1. **Information sharing** in the unit.
2. **Training** of new members and for new practices.
3. **Problem solving** and crisis management, using diverse resources of the group.
4. **Planning** and taking stock of work in progress.

5. **Receiving / demonstrating a new product** (e.g. e-rickshaw) to find lapses.
6. **Decision making** – the overall function of every meeting.

Why meetings fail

- Poor planning – notice of 2–3 hours, no agenda or unprepared members.
- Poor leadership.
- Too many routine meetings; half-hearted, disinterested participation.
- Meetings at very short notice (except emergencies).

Questions before calling a meeting

- **Why** – is a meeting really necessary or is a discussion enough?
- **Who** – only people whose presence matters.
- **When** – check calendars and convenience of key people (by e-mail); avoid evenings after 7 pm; first half preferred by some.
- **Where** – accessible common place; change venues for a series but keep cost low.
- **What** – agenda circulated beforehand.

Arrangements

- Check the venue well in advance: capacity (6–7 to 20 people), electricity, coolers or AC, gadgets, microphones for large groups.
- Pad and pen at each seat; refreshments if possible.
- Agenda well prepared and systematic.

Conducting the meeting

- **Start on time** even if some are late (do not scold latecomers; may say ‘we started without you’).
- **Follow the agenda**; keep the discussion from deviating.
- Allow **full participation**; democratic control; encourage quiet members politely (“Well, Mr X, what is your opinion?”).
- Appoint a **secretary** to record minutes; use official, positive language; do not record unpleasant incidents.
- Be task-centred; finish on time.

Etiquette for participants

- Wait for your turn to speak.
- Switch off cell phones; no satirical language.
- If the meeting overruns because of a domineering person, ask politely: “May I know if the meeting is over?”
- Be an active participant, not a mute spectator.

Closing the meeting

- Summarise the outcomes; identify specifics.
- Assign **responsibilities** and set **deadlines**; decide follow-up.
- Thank the leader/participants; announce that minutes will be circulated.
- Leader resolves conflict neutrally in polite, persuasive language.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Functions of meetings

Function	Purpose
Information sharing	Circulate new information
Training	Induct new employees; introduce practices
Problem solving	Find solutions in crisis
Planning	Plan and review progress
Product demonstration	Test and announce new products
Decision making	Reach a decision

Planning checklist

Question	Consideration
Why?	Clear aim
Who?	Essential people only
When?	Check calendars; daytime
Where?	Accessible, adequate venue
What?	Agenda circulated

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

E-rickshaw as a new product announced internally before launch.

EXAMPLE

Meeting of 6–7 versus 20 people needing different rooms.

EXAMPLE

Latecomer remark: ‘We started without you’.

Comparison tables

Effective versus ineffective meeting

Point	Effective	Ineffective
Notice	Advance with agenda	Hours before
Leadership	Democratic control	Poor leadership
Time	Starts and ends on time	Overruns
Outcome	Decisions and deadlines	No decision

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Meeting = organised gathering for a purpose.
- Overall function of every meeting: decision making.
- Plan with why, who, when, where, what.
- Agenda is circulated in advance.
- Start on time; follow agenda.
- Minutes should not record unpleasant incidents.
- Switch off cell phones.
- Assign responsibilities and deadlines at the end.
- Avoid meetings after 7 pm.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W9 Q13	p.33	Meeting management: agenda	True/False

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Meetings are organised gatherings to share information, train, solve problems, plan, demonstrate products and above all make decisions. They fail through poor planning and leadership. Before calling a meeting ask why, who, when, where and what; check calendars, venue and facilities and circulate the agenda. During the meeting start on time, follow the agenda, encourage participation, record official minutes; participants should follow etiquette. Close by summarising, assigning responsibilities and deadlines and promising to circulate minutes.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) The primary function of every meeting is:

A. Entertainment

B. Decision making

C. Refreshments

D. Socialising

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Meetings finally must come to decisions.

Q2 (MCQ) What should not be recorded in minutes?

A. Decisions

B. Attendance

C. Unpleasant incidents

D. Action points

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** Only official matters.

Q3 (MSQ) Planning questions include:

A. Why

B. Who

C. Where

D. Whom to blame

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** Also when and what.

Q4 (T/F) A meeting should wait until all latecomers arrive.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** Start on time.

Q5 (Fill) The list of items to be discussed is called the _____.

> **Answer:** agenda
> **Why:** Circulated beforehand.

Q6 (Short) What should a leader do when concluding a meeting?

> **Answer:** Summarise outcomes, assign responsibilities, set deadlines, decide follow-up and announce circulation of minutes.
> **Why:** Ensures action.

Revision checklist

☐ I can list meeting functions.
☐ I know why meetings fail.
☐ I can plan using wh-questions.
☐ I know conduct and etiquette.
☐ I know closing steps.

Lecture 45: Adaptability and Work Ethics

Week 9 · Course book PDF pages 732–749 (printed pages 731–748)

Learning objectives

- Define adaptability and explain why employees must adapt.
- Define ethics and work ethics.
- Explain mutual obligations of employer and employee, including Kant's view that employees are ends, not merely means.
- List employee rights: freedom/non-discrimination, privacy, due process, participation, health and safety, fair wages, speech.
- Identify unethical practices and ways to be ethical.

Important definitions

ADAPTABILITY

The ability of an individual or organisation to change itself or its responses to new circumstances, situations or environments; shows the ability to learn.

ETHICS

A sense of righteousness that tells whether actions are right or wrong.

WORK ETHIC

A set of values based on the moral virtues of hard work and diligence, belief in the moral benefit of work and its ability to enhance character (as quoted from Wikipedia).

CODE OF CONDUCT

Written rules and regulations of an organisation; supported by unwritten personal codes.

MORAL HAZARD

Risk that parties in an employer–employee relationship behave unethically.

PLAGIARISM

Reproducing another person's words or ideas as one's own.

PILFERING

Stealing small things slowly and steadily from the organisation.

MISQUOTING / MISREPRESENTING DATA

Reporting what was not said or distorting data to gain advantage.

PROBATION PERIOD

Initial period to judge an employee's capability.

Core concepts

Why adaptability

- Organisations change practices: paperless offices, electronic pay slips, online tax returns.
- Resisting change makes people rigid, isolated and a barrier to communication; adaptable people learn and improve themselves and the organisation's fitness.
- Change is the law of nature; follow the organisational flow of communication.
- Computer literacy spread because people adapted.

Skills needed to adapt

- **Physical** fitness (a sound mind in a sound body).
- **Mental** and **psychological** preparedness.
- Willingness to work in a **multicultural** setting.
- Learn the organisation's culture and code of conduct; remember that you are its ambassador.

Personal ethics at work

- Commitment, reliability, loyalty to organisation over friends and relatives.
- Keep confidential information secret (finance, banking passwords).
- Regular attendance for pay received.
- Honouring the appointment letter, contract and probation; leaving for a small perk soon after joining is an ethical issue.

Employer–employee relationship

- Based on trust and legal obligations; rights come with duties.
- Organisation provides pay, facilities, environment and self-actualisation.
- The employer has authority to monitor and control, and may invest in the employee.
- **Immanuel Kant:** employees should be treated as **ends, not only means**; occupation gives awareness of one's powers and happiness; 'man feels contented after heavy work'.

Employee rights

- **Right to freedom / non-discrimination** – on gender, colour, faith, age, disability.
- **Right to privacy** – personal data and habits, except where safety demands (e.g. testing a pilot for alcohol); work–life balance (no odd-hour duties for women).
- **Right to due process** – equal criteria for promotion and fair treatment in layoffs with adequate time and compensation.
- **Right to participation and association** – consulted in decisions such as closing a unit.
- **Right to health and safe working conditions** – well-being measures, helmets, yoga, swimming.

- **Right to fair wages** – same pay for same work.
- **Right to freedom of conscience and speech** – but not anti-organisational.

Unethical practices to avoid

- Plagiarism.
- Misusing office resources (phone, property); pilfering.
- Selective misquoting.
- Taking credit for others' work.
- Misrepresenting data; distorting visuals; exaggeration.
- Criticising the organisation or colleagues publicly.
- Conflict of loyalties: personal ethics versus organisational code (e.g. evaluating a loss-making unit that will cause redundancies).

How to be ethical

- Follow written and unwritten codes of conduct.
- Be honest, transparent, sincere, hardworking, an ambassador of the organisation.
- Love your work; speak well of the organisation.
- Protect confidential information.
- Respect all faiths and beliefs in a multicultural workplace.
- Balance rights and duties.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Employee rights

Right	Meaning
Freedom / non-discrimination	Equal opportunity regardless of gender, colour, faith, age, disability
Privacy	Personal data protected except for safety
Due process	Equal criteria for promotion and termination
Participation	Involved in decisions
Health and safety	Safe conditions and well-being
Fair wages	Equal pay for equal work
Speech	Express views without harming organisation

Unethical practices

Practice	Description
Plagiarism	Using others' work as own
Misuse of resources	Using office property/phone personally
Misquoting	Selective or false reporting
Credit stealing	Taking credit for others' work
Data misrepresentation	Distorting facts

Theories, principles, models and contributors

EMPLOYEES AS ENDS — IMMANUEL KANT

Persons must never be treated merely as means but also as ends; work brings awareness of one's powers and contentment.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Paperless office and electronic pay slips.

EXAMPLE

Pilot tested for alcohol.

EXAMPLE

Leaving a job after two months for higher pay.

EXAMPLE

Evaluating a loss-making unit leading to layoffs.

Comparison tables

Adaptable versus rigid employee

Point	Adaptable	Rigid
Attitude to change	Welcomes	Resists
Learning	Continuous	Stagnant
Organisational view	Valued contributor	Sidelined, isolated

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Adaptability = ability to change to new circumstances.
- Ethics = sense of right and wrong.
- Work ethic is based on hard work and diligence.
- Kant: treat employees as ends, not only means.
- Rights come with duties.
- Loyalty to organisation outweighs loyalty to friends in confidentiality.
- Rights listed: freedom, privacy, due process, participation, health, fair wages, speech.
- Unethical: plagiarism, misuse, misquoting, credit stealing.
- Employees are ambassadors of the organisation.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W5 Q3	p.19	Ethical breakdown	Fill-in-the-blank
W9 Q11	p.33	Adaptability	True/False
W9 Q15	p.33	Work ethics	True/False

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Adaptability is the ability to change with new circumstances; it helps employees learn and strengthens the organisation. Ethics is the sense of right and wrong; work ethics rests on hard work, diligence, reliability and loyalty. Employer–employee relations are bound by trust and law; Kant argues employees are ends, not merely means. Employees have rights – freedom from discrimination, privacy, due process, participation, safe conditions, fair wages and speech – and duties. Avoid plagiarism, misuse of resources, misquoting, credit stealing and data misrepresentation; follow the code of conduct and act as the organisation's ambassador.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) Who said employees should be treated as ends and not merely means?

A. Kant
B. Tuckman
C. Drucker
D. Gunning

> **Answer:** A
> **Why:** Immanuel Kant.

Q2 (MCQ) Which is an unethical workplace practice?

A. Plagiarism

B. Punctuality

C. Honesty

D. Loyalty

> **Answer:** A
> **Why:** Plagiarism is intellectual theft.

Q3 (MSQ) Which are employee rights discussed?

A. Privacy

B. Due process

C. Fair wages

D. Right to leak secrets

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** Secrets must be protected.

Q4 (T/F) Organisations may test pilots for alcohol despite the right to privacy.

> **Answer:** True
> **Why:** Safety justifies it.

Q5 (Fill) With rights come _____.

> **Answer:** duties
> **Why:** Balance both.

Q6 (Short) Why must employees adapt to change?

> **Answer:** Organisations evolve; adapting lets employees learn, remain useful, avoid isolation and improve the organisation's fitness.
> **Why:** Change is the law of nature.

Revision checklist

☐ I can define adaptability and ethics.

☐ I know employer–employee obligations.

☐ I can list employee rights.

☐ I can list unethical practices.

☐ I recall Kant.